

Hey, friends, it is Eric Malzone. And in this short audio lecture, we are going to talk about learning from and applying feedback. Whether you're a seasoned content creator or you're just getting started, feedback-- good, bad, indifferent-- can be incredibly valuable. It can also be really counter-productive, and at times a strong deterrent from continuing.

So I want to start with a quote. Our old friend Teddy Roosevelt once said, "it is not the critic who counts, not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood, who strives valiantly, who errs and comes up short again, and again," end quote.

OK, I'm very aware that that quote can be a little cliched at times, and probably incorrectly taken out of context. It's a little cheesy. It's not lost on me. But it sums up the point. And it kind of fires me up, to be honest with you.

So, listen, if you start to put yourself out there, you're going to get some feedback. And the funny thing is, the more successful you, get as far as your reach and consumption, the more feedback you're going to get. So it's the price of admission. And when used properly, when leveraged well, it's incredibly valuable.

I have a couple of rules of thumb that I'd like to start off with here, what I consider feedback from audience colleagues, friends and family. Number one is always focus on the long game. Remember, there's not a single comment or one episode that's going to dramatically change the trajectory of your podcast.

So think long-term-- years, not weeks. Celebrate the positive feedback. Make an example of it.

If you've ever coached people, which a lot of you probably have, and as a former gym owner, I always try to exemplify the behavior that I wanted. And I'm not talking about just random praise, but behavior that was constructive, supportive of the community. So when you get a chance, celebrate those and make an example of them.

Show restraint. Be stoic in nature when it comes to feedback. Find the opportunities for improvement, and kind of toss the rest.

Be proactive. Best feedback doesn't always come to you. So it's at the dinner table, it's at lunch where you're talking to a colleague or someone who may be listening to your podcast, or surveys, things like that. You've got to be proactive. You've got to go out and get the stuff that tends to be the best.

Feedback means people are listening, so celebrate that, as well. Once you're starting to get feedback, it's actually a really big milestone, in my opinion. The first review you get, whatever it may be, just know that that means people are listening.

So let's move on to the importance of feedback. Number one, enhancing the content quality. Feedback helps you understand what resonates with your audience and what does not, guiding your entire process of refinement. So specific topics, formats, styles, titles, thumbnails, et cetera-- this is all opportunities to get some feedback, and change things slowly along the way.

Building audience connection-- actively engaging with feedback shows your listeners that you value their opinions. This fosters stronger connections, and it boosts that net promoter effect.

Continuous improvement-- feedback provides insights into areas for improvement, ensuring your podcast evolves and stays relevant. Especially when it comes to fitness, health and wellness, we are in a constant hype cycle. So we want to make sure that things are both engaging with people on current topics and trends, but also providing them the good, solid information they need to improve their health and fitness.

Gathering feedback-- so how do we actually get it in? First of all, multiple channels. Try to keep things balanced in the way you collect feedback.

So various channels like social media, emails, podcast reviews and direct listener messages are really good ways. There's a whole plethora of ways to do that. But look for different channels, because audiences live in different places.

Surveys and polls-- we were talking about being proactive. Use tools like Google Forms or social media polls to gather structured feedback on specific aspects of your podcast, things that you know are constructive and valuable to improving the show.

Encouraging reviews-- prompt your listeners to leave reviews and ratings on podcast platforms, providing valuable insights into their listening experience. I'm not really sure how that affects algorithms, exactly, but I'm pretty confident it does in a positive way. So if you're getting more good reviews, you're getting more engagement, you tend to be found more in various things like Apple and Spotify.

So how do you actually interpret the feedback once you have it? First and foremost, identify the patterns. Look for recurring themes in the feedback.

Are they consistent compliments or criticisms? Well then, maybe they should be taken more seriously. The one-off stuff you can probably throw out.

Context matters. Consider the context of the feedback. A one-time comment may not be as impactful as a repeated feedback on the same issue or trend. Kind of a little expansion of what I said above.

Constructive criticism-- so focus on constructive criticism that offers specific suggestions for improvement, rather than vague or overly negative comments. So things that you can actually use, right? That's it.

So applying the feedback. So once you have gathered it, you've interpreted it, how do you apply it? Well, actionable changes.

So translate the feedback into actionable steps for your podcast journey. If listeners mentioned audio quality issues, then invest in better equipment, editing software, or a new service. Consult with other podcasters or content professionals.

Experiment and adjust-- implement changes gradually and track their impact. Experiment with different formats, topics, styles, based on that feedback, as well.

Communicate the changes. This is really important, I believe. It's a two-way street. I know it may feel like you're sitting there and you're just putting content out one way, but it is a two-way street.

So keep your audience informed about the changes you're making based on their feedback. Mention it in the podcast. Mention it in your social media. Always attribute any particular listeners to the feedback that you've been actionable on. And this transparency builds trust, it builds engagement, and it's an interesting sense of empathy that you get with your audience, as well.

So this has probably been on a lot of your minds-- overcoming negative feedback. Like I said, I bring stoicism to a lot of things that I do, and it couldn't be more applicable in this case. Stay objective. Like everything in the age of social media, don't take negative feedback personally.

Stay stoic with it. This means look for the usefulness, look for the utility in each comment. And if there's nothing there, then you move on. It's just that simple.

They probably have no idea who you even are. And by the time you read it and maybe you get upset about it, they've probably moved on to the next victim. So just consider that, as well. But do take it seriously at times, because there could be really valuable nuggets in there that you can actually use to make things better.

Engage constructively-- so if you do decide to engage, and as hard as it may be at times, respond professionally to negative feedback, addressing valid concerns and thanking your reviewer for their input. It always helps to take a walk. If you read it, I would even suggest a full 24 hours before responding.

Emotions may have subsided. You can look at it a different way. Maybe you've gotten some feedback from a significant other on it.

But use that time period. There's no rush. The comment isn't going anywhere. And I just think that's a good rule of thumb for life, in general.

Balance perspective-- so balance negative feedback with positive comments. Focus on continuous improvement. Don't focus on perfection. That's the name of the game here. This is a process-- refine, repeat.

So in recap, we basically discussed the opportunities and the importance of feedback-- how to gather it, how to interpret it, and the best ways to actually apply it to your podcast. I encourage you that feedback is a very powerful tool for growth. Embrace it, learn from it, let it guide your podcast journey, and just frame things with the right perspective. A little bit of gratitude and a growth mindset goes a long way.

[MUSIC PLAYING]